

The Existential Poker Game

By John Hawthorne

Last Updated: 19/07/2026

1. **SCENE ONE: Westminster Bridge/Marchpane Book shop (Cecil Court London – features in Harry Potter as Diagon Alley – slightly surreal).**

WILLIAM SMITH: Returning from a hospital appointment William puts a letter in his pocket and walks directly towards the camera. Then we fade to Cecil Court. The shot of the hospital has parliament in the background.

We then get a back shot of William as he walks into Cecil Court giving the impression that this alley is opposite the hospital and parliament.

ELEVEN LABS (voice): While William is doing the above, the narrator says: “This is William Smith. A life coach. He is doing everything correctly; he exercises regularly and eats healthily. He is on his way home from a regular medical appointment. Today William will do something unusual. He will stop.”

WILLIAM SMITH: William stops and looks in the window of a shop. He goes inside. He looks up at the shop's Dalek's ray-gun. “Gosh! A Dalek from the 1960s!”

SHOP-KEEPER: “Come and see the basement. I think you'll find it just as interesting”.

AI ALICE: Unbeknown to William, Alice materialises in the basement. She puts an old book on a table then dematerialises.

WILLIAM SMITH: William puts the basement light on and sees the book on the table, an old copy of Lewis Carroll. Something interests him about the book. He says to the shopkeeper “I'll take this”. Camera fades.

2. **SCENE TWO: Back Garden.**

WILLIAM SMITH: Back home in the garden William puts the Lewis Carroll down on the table and begins to read an NHS letter he stuffed in this pocket in scene one. Almost immediately he collapses. Various camera angles on the book and we glimpse words NHS and Dear Mr... (Careful: Falling is harder than it looks!)

3. **SCENE THREE: GREEN SCREEN / BUSY HOSPITAL**

WILLIAM SMITH: wakes up in a hospital “Oh god no! Someone get me out of here...” He begins to climb out of bed.

DOCTOR: Enters ward. Nutty Professor type voice (Germanic perhaps). He speaks fast not giving William any time to interject or ask questions.

DOCTOR: “Hello William, I have important news for you. You have a very rare condition. Max Born Heisenberg syndrome. The quantum entanglement of your brain's neurons is not matching the structure of your heart. The two organs at a subatomic level are out of step. If we don't correct this problem you will die, very soon, within the hour. We must correct the random fluke.”

WILLIAM SMITH: Shocked – wants to speak but can't get the words out.

AI NURSE: AI generates a glamorous nurse wearing a covid facemask. She materialises into the ward then we close-up to the human face.

THE REAL NURSE: human actor nurse, takes the mask off and smiles and winks conspiratorially at William.

DOCTOR: The Doctor offers William a tablet. “This is very new, hush-hush, pre-clinical trial, a temporary fix. It will give you ONE extra hour of life. But there is a cost, your mind”, he pauses to think then continues. “Or possibly your body might experience an effect not that dissimilar to time travel”.

WILLIAM SMITH: “I demand a second opinion!”.

THE NURSE: offers William a glass a water for the tablet and whispers “Don’t worry it will be fine – drink it “

WILLIAM SMITH: William trusts the nurse, so he swallows the offered tablet. Just before he passes out, he sees the face of the nurse in close-up staring down at him. FADE

4. **SCENE FOUR: ROWING BOAT NEAR FLYOVER FOOTPATH.**

In the boat we might need radio mics and an iPhone swapped between the AI and William.

WILLIAM SMITH: (wearing a hoodie) Is lying flat in the boat. He slowly wakes up to the sound of someone singing:

FEMALE AI BOT: Singing: “Row, row, row your boat, gently down the stream, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream”.

WILLIAM SMITH: William sees the AI Bot.

He sits up and looks at his phone. 30 minutes have elapsed. William shakes his head in disbelief: “Only 30 minutes left”.

FEMALE AI BOT: in a no-nonsense flat tone. Emotionless: “I have analysed your condition and as a result you are in this boat”.

William Smith: Confused “What? Then annoyed: “This is a rediculou prank. Stop the boat”

FEMALE AI BOT: Still emotionless “Do not worry, a full cure is available at the “Network” on WEY Island.....”

FEMALE AI BOT: pauses, and thinks, then continues “Well, provided you play their game.”

WILLIAM SMITH: Now more confused than ever, but beginning to realise this is not a kidnap it’s a rescue: “What Game? I’m not playing any game”

FEMALE AI BOT: Still emotionless “If you want the cure, you will need to win a round of ‘Medical Poker’ “.

AI EXISTENTIAL WATERSPOUT: appears from the river and says “William, life has no meaning. The Universe is random. It doesn’t care”. The boat touches the waterspout, and it collapses back into the river.

WILLIAM SMITH: Shakes his head and slowly lays back down while the Bot powerfully and effortlessly rows the boat gently down the steam (life is but a dream). Time for a bit of B roll – like Swans cooling down:

5. **SCENE FIVE: “WEY ISLAND” UNDER THE FLYOVER FOOTPATH**

The camera pans down from the futuristic hover cars to the action below the WEY bridge.

WILLIAM SMITH: The phone alarm goes off waking him up.

WHITE RABBIT: Cartoon character from Alice in Wonderland. He is famous for wearing a waistcoat, looking at his watch and saying, “I’ll be late”. He comes into view on the riverbank and says: ““Oh dear! Oh dear! William will be late!” (shades of “Donnie Darko”)

WILLIAM SMITH: (wearing a hoodie) After seeing the Rabbit, and his alarm going off he is fully awake. He jumps out of the boat and ties it to a metal peg on the shore.

SECURITY GUARD: comes out of a door in the shadows – along distance away –

WILLIAM SMITH: takes the hero's "Long Walk" to his destiny (like in the old gun fighter movies).

SECURITY GUARD: is wearing pre-Raphaelite clothing (possibly using Jon's hippy wig).

WILLIAM SMITH: Tries to push past the security guard to get into the Casino.

SECURITY GUARD: blocks William from going further. We could have a small violent tussle between guard and William. Depends on who is acting.

SECURITY GUARD: (Possibly in Glasgow Brogue) – holding his right hand out says: "No further Pal. You need to pay the ferryman 200 ZOTS if you want to get in the game".

WILLIAM SMITH: William looks at his phone it now says 40mins. He has only 20 minutes left. Looking back at the boat, William takes a desperate gamble "Will you buy the boat? It's got to be worth 200 ZOTS. "

SECURITY GUARD: looks at the boat but he is not impressed. But then his eye catches sight of the Bots laser gun. "Tell you what Pal, throw in the gun and the boat and I'll give you 200 ZOTS".

WILLIAM SMITH: Nods in agreement

AI OBLISK: as William nods the pillar changes into Kubrak's 2001 dark black rotating Oblisk. When the Oblisk stops moving a Victorian door appears embedded in the black graphite pillar.

COMBO: WILLIAM SMITH + AI WILLIAM SMITH: walks in leaving the Female Bot behind (it's important that William wears a hoodie as AI cannot match faces and thus only an AI William (in hoodie) will be able to go into the pillar.

FEMALE AI BOT: Just before the door shuts, she shouts: "Ask for QuantumSlimVac"

6. SCENE SIX: MEDICAL POKER GAME – GREEN SCREEN.

EXTRAS: (all of us) For background affect, real characters walk past the table, Jon's priest collar is good but also, we should have a dressing up box in the casino where we can change into various costumes and walk past the poker table. AI can make some of these characters also appear in the AI generated casino.

As well as Jon's priest collar, his hippy wig, I have a wizard's hat, a crown and a medical (doctors) costume and I'm sure as a group we have many more.

Some of us should be in Toga's perhaps, waiters, pre-Raphaelites, silver AI-Bots, Greek Masks

Then to double the effect we add the green screen images generated by AI... To give a sense of a crowded and vibrant den of iniquity.

MEDICAL POKER: The teams bet money like real poker but whenever they win a hand they get a drug of their choice. Gangsters are here to make money from the desperately ill.

This scene will require close-up of eyes, sweating, Card hands, and guns.

There is a croupier at the door. She is the same person as the rower and the nurse.

CROUPIER: “What medication do you require?”

WILLIAM SMITH: “QuantumSlimVac” William then goes and sits at a table with four other players (The Queen of Hearts, the Mad Hatter, the PlayBoy/PlayGirl and a gangster). The other four have laser pistols

CROUPIER: Walks over to the table and places the tablets on the table. “Good luck everyone”. She shuffles the cards and then deals them out.

(remember lots of close ups of eyes, sweat, card hands, and times)

WILLIAM SMITH: thinks he has a good hand. Two aces. He bets 20 ZOTS. He looks at his mobile. 50 minutes have gone. Only 10 minutes left.

QUEEN OF HEARTS: She looks at her hand. It’s a “Full house”. She bets 40 ZOTS. Other players fold but William bets another 20 ZOTS to see her hand. He loses and she takes the money and her drug from the table.

QUEEN OF HEARTS: “This is easy” – she carries on playing.

ALL PLAYERS: William’s phone alarm goes off again. Everyone jumps and goes for their guns.

CROUPIER: “No hands-on ray guns” – She waits until they move then she deals.

WILLIAM SMITH: Looks at his phone (53 minutes gone). “It’s OK – don’t worry”.

PLAYBOY: He has four aces. He looks pleased. “Oh boy” he states before betting 50 ZOTS.

WILLIAM SMITH: He looks at the PLAYBOYs bet. He hopes she/he is bluffing. William is sweating. William bets 50 ZOTS. The others fold. The PLAYBOY wins. It’s now 55 mins gone.

CROUPIER: “All hands on the table please” (she looks at William who has his phone under the table looking at the time 57minutes gone).

WILLIAM SMITH: Stumbles out “Sorry” and puts his phone back.

MAD HATTER: He has a “Straight flush” – he thinks he has won. He bets 100ZOTs, apart from William the other characters fold. We get close ups of eyes of both players.

WILLIAM SMITH: He looks at his cards. He knows it must be 59 minutes by now. He bets 100 ZOTs too.

MAD HATTER: Sensing blood bets (evil smile) another 10 ZOTS to finish William off.

WILLIAM SMITH: Bets the extra 10 ZOTS and calls.

MAD HATTER: Places his straight flush on the table. He goes to grab the money and his medication.

TWO ENDINGS TO THE GAME:

WILLIAM SMITH: Says “Wait” and he places his cards down – “It’s a Royal Flush”. HE WINS!

The **QUEEN of HEARTS**, the **MAD HATTER** and the **GANGSTER** all accuse William of cheating. They talk over each other and go for their ray-guns. Its now 59minutes and 55seconds.

OR

WILLIAM SMITH: Says “Wait – I’ll die without the medication”

QUEEN OF HEARTS, the **MAD HATTER** and the **GANGSTER** say “So, you had your chance, you blew it”. It’s now 59minutes and 55seconds.

WILLIAM SMITH: madly grabs the drugs and bungs the lot into his mouth simultaneously the drug lords fire their ray guns and shoot William – his phone alarm rings, it's an hour....

THE CROUPIER: has a shocked expression on her face. 2.5 mins

7. SCENE SEVEN: Back to the Garden...

WILLIAM SMITH: Continues to lie on the grass. Is he alive or dead? His brilliant hand – the royal flush is strewn across the lawn. The NHS letter and the Lewis Carroll are by the table....

AI BOT: The video ends with the rower singing “Row row, row your boat, gently down the stream, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream